

9, Clearly Defined Land Ownership is the Fundamental Prerequisite for Feudalization

Beyond the aforementioned factors, there is another critical issue: **feudal society** intrinsically demands crystalline boundaries for the territories held by its lords! From the lowliest nobility to the most formidable monarch, explicitly defining "*who governs which land*" is absolutely paramount to the formation of **feudalism**. Even for the peasants attached to a **feudal lord**, the specific types of property rights they hold over specific plots of land must be unambiguously codified. The rights and obligations between rulers and the ruled, as well as among rulers of varying echelons, must be rigidly stipulated through contracts (契约) mutually acknowledged by all parties.

Although China never experienced a genuine **feudal society**—and consequently Chinese people, naturally including myself, inherently lack any historical memory of a **feudal society**—through my limited observation of Europe and Japan, I firmly assert this: **The precise demarcation of power boundaries and the awakening of rights consciousness (权利意识) represent the most monumental achievements humanity attained during the feudal era! They rendered a staggeringly indispensable contribution to our march toward modern civilization.** And this achievement is absolutely inseparable from the definitive confirmation of land rights (土地确权).

The Great Expansion does not abruptly terminate the moment a **classical empire** is born. Relying on its formidable national power and centralized apparatus, the empire can pursue neighboring barbarians deep into their own territories, stretching its frontiers to unfathomable distances.

However, at the absolute terminal nerve-endings of imperial power, there fundamentally lacks sufficient population to execute actual development. The scale of civilian migration is woefully insufficient to alter local cultural customs, let alone ethnic compositions. The empire's presence here relies entirely upon minuscule garrisons in isolated colonial cities to control crucial transportation arteries, maintain a military deterrent against peripheral backward peoples, exact certain tributes, or merely demand nominal subjugation. Alternatively, it merely manifests as military fortresses guarding against potential foreign invasions. An infinitesimally small number of imperial citizens voluntarily engage in commercial activities here, and the labor force in military agricultural colonies (屯垦区) is almost entirely forcibly relocated via administrative mandates.

Overall, the classical empire's investments in these frontier zones glaringly exceed its revenues. Unless there are high-quality mineral deposits to extract, governing such frontiers is driven overwhelmingly by political and military intentions. (*One merely needs to observe the frontiers of the Han, Wei, and Jin dynasties or the Roman Empire to understand this; I will not elaborate further*).

Some might suspect: *If the population of a classical empire continued to multiply indefinitely, could these "fuzzy frontiers" (模糊边疆) eventually evolve into solid hinterlands, serving as springboards for even further expansion?*

However, history seemingly repudiates this possibility. The advancement of human society is wave-like: during certain epochs, it surges forward explosively; during others, it appears to plunge into stagnation. **A classical empire possesses zero opportunity to utilize surplus labor to permanently saturate these frontiers! Long before it can do so, it will inevitably disintegrate amidst the inexorable process of feudalization.** In fact, as we shall soon see, these exact types of "fuzzy frontiers" hold monumental significance for the **feudalization** orchestrated by **barbarians**!

In summary, no matter how formidable a **classical empire** is, its territorial expanse will eventually hit an absolute upper limit (上界); and **feudalization** earliest materializes strictly within this geographical perimeter.

If one examines European history, it is effortless to notice that throughout the Early Middle Ages, the establishment of feudal regimes basically never transcended the maximum frontiers of the Roman Empire! The massive agricultural development of the Germanic regions only truly commenced during the **High Middle Ages**. The same holds true for China. Even though the bureaucratic system later achieved its **restoration** in our nation, the civilizational boundaries forged by the Han Dynasty remained fundamentally unaltered for over ten centuries following the collapse of the Eastern Han! The only difference was that the frontiers *already* secured by the Han Dynasty became fully developed.

It is said that the Japanese text *Gen'i Shū* (源威集) records a highly legendary tale: when Hōjō Masako (北条政子) was young, she had a dream in which she married a colossal giant who "*lay stretched from Kikaijima (鬼界島) to Sotogahama (外浜).*" This tale was utilized to legitimize the Minamoto clan's (源氏) rule over the realm. From Kikaijima to Sotogahama—meaning from the southernmost tip of Kyushu to the northernmost tip of Honshu—this perfectly delineated the absolute entirety of Japan's national territory at the dawn of the Middle Ages! And that giant sprawling across this territory, was it not the perfect metaphor for the Samurai (武士) who were destined to govern this very land?

The Great Expansion officially concludes upon reaching a definitive, finite boundary, and this historical culmination similarly irreversibly alters the macro-consciousness of the entire society.

Imagine how the Japanese during the Asuka and Nara periods (飞鸟奈良时期) viewed the world! For them, "subjugating the barbarians" (征夷) was merely a matter of timing, devoid of any technological hurdles. As long as the imperial court amassed surplus wealth, continuously driving the Emishi (虾夷人) further north was never an issue.

But by the era of the *Taiheiki* (太平记 / 14th century), societal consciousness could fundamentally no longer operate like that! Japan's national boundaries had become absolutely fixed. The land under heaven had become a zero-sum game: "**If you gain a parcel, I must lose a parcel!**"

It was precisely this hyper-acute consciousness revolving around land appropriation that catalyzed immensely positive effects for the formation of **feudalism**. For a nation with such unique characteristics as Japan, this was astronomically vital. At this exact moment in history, the insular, geographically closed nature of the island nation miraculously transformed into an absolute blessing!

However, the distinct peculiarity of the **feudal period** lies precisely in this: **people's subjective perception of the era violently diverged from the objective advancement of social development**. The same principle applies here.

When civilization expanded to its absolute limits, population growth inevitably meant land became increasingly scarce, because the easily developable virgin lands within the empire had fundamentally been exhausted. The massive land annexations by early **feudal manors** (封建庄园) and the massive influx of **barbarians** drastically exacerbated this crisis.

And the terrible events did not stop there. The acute tension in the population-to-land ratio, urban decay, and the disintegration of political order could inflict catastrophic devastation upon public health. For instance, we observe that highly destructive plagues proliferated during both the twilight of the Eastern Han Dynasty and the reign of Justinian.

Consequently, the confident, open, inclusive, proactive, and optimistic ethos forged during **The Great Expansion** and sustained through the zenith of **classical empires** was rapidly annihilated within just a century or two! The societal atmosphere grew increasingly anti-rational, and skepticism ran rampant. People grew profoundly pessimistic about the future, and their thoughts and actions became increasingly narrow-minded and parochial. This was entirely understandable at the time, for the world had genuinely become a far more dangerous place; people had every reason to harbor intense vigilance against those different from themselves.

What I specifically wish to emphasize here is this: **Although social consciousness seemingly regressed at the very onset of feudalization, many transformations that would later prove monumentally significant had already quietly begun!**

For instance, after people were violently compelled to abandon grand imperial narratives, they began to focus far more intensely on the destiny of the individual and engage in individualistic creation! China's *Nineteen Old Poems* (古诗十九首) serves as a perfect example. People ceased to care about the massive "communities" (大共同体) that once dominated social life—whether that be the imperial court, provincial governments, the legions, or the state church—because they were either already utterly destroyed or struggling just to save themselves.

Instead, individuals sought personal salvation and liberation. The religions that perfectly adapted to this trend undeniably secured spectacular triumphs, maintaining their global prestige to this day! Intellectuals began to desperately ponder the underlying causes behind the world's mutations and how humans ought to navigate such agonizing times. Keen observation and deep introspection became the dominant themes of writing—just like Japan's *Gukanshō* (愚管抄), *Tsurezuregusa* (徒然草), and *Jinnō Shōtōki* (神皇正統記).

Judged from today's perspective, these new consciousnesses were still exceptionally immature. The stances of certain authors were not aligned with historical progress, and some of their conclusions have long since been repudiated. **Yet, it was precisely the profound contemplations forged in those eras of chaos and peril that constituted the genesis point for the eventual pacification and rebuilding of the world!**

The ambiguity of borders becoming an obstruction to **feudalization** harbors another easily recognizable problem. For a **classical empire**, behind these shifting borders, there inevitably existed multitudes of "uncivilized peoples" (化外之民) sheltered behind natural geographical barriers—and their numbers were substantial! Otherwise, what reason would the empire have not to push its borders forward to a secure, easily defensible position?

This phenomenon was glaringly conspicuous in the regions dominated by the tropical monsoon climate across South and Southeast Asia. These regions were densely cloaked in jungles, and their annual precipitation was appallingly uneven. A tropical monsoon climate differs entirely from a tropical rainforest climate: the latter's rainfall is relatively evenly distributed throughout the year, but the former's precipitation is catastrophically concentrated within less than one-third of the year

under the monsoon's influence. Furthermore, the protracted dry season is sub-divided into a "hot season" (热季) and a "cool season" (凉季).

This dynamic diverges radically from the temperate zones. In the North Temperate Zone, the sun's angle of incidence peaks at the summer solstice; because heat must accumulate, the hottest period of the year falls between July and August. However, half of the Indian subcontinent and virtually the entire Indochinese peninsula lie south of the Tropic of Cancer! This means a massive portion of this region is already blasted by direct solar radiation *before* the summer solstice. While the North Temperate Zone is still in spring, these regions have already become excruciatingly scorching. Even in our modern era, news frequently reports mass casualties from heatstroke in India during April and May.

As the monsoons arrive bearing torrential downpours, the extreme heat is somewhat mitigated, but roads are instantly severed, and the perils of travel skyrocket! Even the most fiercely resolute, lightly-packed ascetic monks are compelled to settle down temporarily during the rainy season (雨季安居), let alone merchants transporting cargo or a massive marching army!

Throughout the entire classical period, India was perpetually forced to confront this reality. Even the capacity of the government fluctuated cyclically with the seasons! Only during the cool season could political power be projected to its maximum radius; during the rainy season, it drastically withered.

This is astonishingly similar to the **Mandala system** (曼荼罗体制) proposed by scholars when describing the history of Southeast Asia. *(Southern India probably fits this even better, as it was developed later, had a smaller population, and lacked massive, contiguous fertile plains. Furthermore, as **feudal society** developed, this phenomenon would inevitably be drastically eradicated, because **feudalization** fundamentally necessitates that state politics transition into a continuous "surface area" (面状) topology—this rule is immutable everywhere).*

The Mandala system lacks explicitly defined national borders; rather, it operates as a nexus of vassalage and tributary relationships centered around a powerful core state. It heavily emphasizes personal allegiance between rulers. Vassals can simultaneously possess their own vassal systems and declare fealty to multiple suzerains simultaneously!

Because India's historical processes initiated relatively early, its population density grew correspondingly high. During the Indian Middle Ages *(from the collapse of the Gupta Empire to the consolidation of the Mughal Empire—a timeframe remarkably close to Europe's. However, I believe the end of this period did not signify that India had already evolved into late feudal society; rather, Europeans arrived relatively early, subjecting India to external influence and gradually reducing it to a colony)*, as population skyrocketed and massive land reclamation progressed, the shadows of the Mandala system eventually vanished from both Northern and Southern India.

Even so, in the late 19th century—when Britain fully controlled India—roughly one-tenth of India's population still resided in forests and hilly terrains! Their most glaring distinction from other Indian inhabitants was that they lacked the caste system. They were referred to as "tribal populations" (部落居民), a nomenclature even the British colonial government retained during its censuses. Two centuries earlier, during the reign of Emperor Aurangzeb (奥朗则布), peasant flight remained a crippling severe problem simply because arable land remained relatively abundant.

These facts dictate that until the British established a military presence with an overwhelming superiority over indigenous rulers on the South Asian subcontinent, for the 2,000 years following the dawn of the classical era, the Indians—despite constantly attempting to compress their "**internal frontiers**" (内部边疆)—never successfully completed the eradication process!

This forms a staggering contrast with temperate regions. One simply cannot fathom that in 1840, within the heartland of China under the Qing Dynasty's rule, 10% of the population—equating to 40 million people!—could roam entirely outside the grasp of the state apparatus, treating the imperial court's laws as nonexistent. In **feudal** Europe or Japan, this is equally unimaginable!

Forests, hills, and mountainous terrains forged colossal "frontier zones" right within the interior of Indian civilization. This meant that even progressing into the Middle Ages, the jurisdictional boundaries of a **feudal lord** were phenomenally difficult to demarcate! The situation was even more severe during the preceding **classical empire** era. Among the various **classical empires** across the Eurasian landmass, the frontiers of China and Rome were the most rigidly defined, whereas those of India's Maurya and Gupta Empires (孔雀王朝和笈多王朝) were the most nebulous. Basically, no one can accurately delineate exactly where the borders of these two empires should be drawn—this is particularly glaring along their southern flanks!

Beyond the perimeter of "Civilized India," there perpetually existed an alternative society accommodating tribal members, runaway peasants, egalitarians, and those unwilling to submit to government jurisdiction. This might sound idyllic, but it was undeniably detrimental to the consolidation of a **feudal system**! Countless massive and minuscule **communities** (社群) operated autonomously within their respective territories. The state apparatus could merely attempt to rein them in, but fundamentally lacked the capacity to annihilate them.

Consequently, India as a whole struggled monumentally to manifest a distinct, sharply stratified class society morphology. The sheer number and proportion of the population drifting outside the "*lord-vassal / lord-peasant*" (领主-领民) system were simply too staggeringly high! It wasn't until the eve of the British invasion that the power of these **communities** began to suffer significant decay. Yet, it is widely acknowledged that even today, the "community" remains a hyper-sensitive topic in India, frequently wielded as a banner for political mobilization. Its terrifyingly enduring influence is clearly evident.

Iran suffered from strikingly parallel afflictions. Although its western frontiers bordered the highly developed regions of the Near East, its frontiers facing Afghanistan and Central Asia to the east were atrociously nebulous. The Alborz Mountains (厄尔布尔士山脉) in the north historically served as an absolute paradise for resisters—they even violently resisted Iran's own central government!

Considering that the Iranian region (*measured by the territories ruled by the Sasanian Empire* / 萨珊帝国) at least did not suffer from cyclical seasonal shifts causing communications to be intermittently severed or government power to perpetually wax and wane like the Indian subcontinent, the total number and proportion of "uncivilized peoples" (化外之民) in Iran should have been smaller than in India. **However, they were infinitely more destructive!**

The tribal residents of India merely wanted to be left alone to live their own lives. They possessed neither the necessity nor the desire to organize; they merely expressed a passive resistance against regional Indian governments and rarely harbored intentions of launching reverse invasions.

The tribes dwelling in the Iranian mountains were an entirely different beast! Merely to survive, they were compelled to maintain a potent military force. When the timing was ripe, it was entirely plausible for them—under the command of a **Charismatic leader**—to conquer a chaotic Iran, or at least a massive chunk of it! This dynamic became glaringly conspicuous following the mass migrations of the Turkic peoples (突厥人大迁徙).

For Iran, the belated commencement of the **feudalization** process triggered a devastating chain reaction. Battered by wave after wave of invaders, Iran during the Middle Ages genuinely plunged into the terrifying "**Chaotic Era**" (乱纪元) straight out of the novel *The Three-Body Problem*!

9, 明确的土地所有权界定是封建化的基本条件

除此之外还有另一个问题, 那就是封建社会本身要求领主之间的领地具有清晰的边界, 从最低级的贵族到最强大的君主, 明确“何人治何土”对封建主义的形成至关重要。即使对于附属于领主的农民来说, 他对于哪些土地拥有何种产权都需要得到清楚确定。统治者和被统治者之间以及各级统治者之间的权利和义务关系需要用被双方认可的契约加以规定。虽然中国没有经历过真正的封建社会, 中国人自然也包括我缺乏对于封建社会的历史记忆, 通过对于欧洲和日本有限的观察, 我认为对于权力的清晰界定和权利意识是封建时代人类取得的最大成就, 并且对于迈向现代文明厥功至伟, 这就离不开土地确权。大扩张不会因为古典帝国的诞生就立刻结束, 帝国凭借强大的国力和集权体制能够对于邻近的蛮族深入穷追, 把边疆扩张到不可思议的远处。在帝国权力的末端, 已经没有足够的人口对这里进行开发, 移民的规模不足以改变当地的文化习俗, 更不要说是民族构成了。帝国在这里的存在依靠着个别殖民城市中的少量驻军控制交通要道, 对于周边落后民族保持威慑, 对他们征收一定的贡品甚至只要求名义上的臣服。要么就是在军事堡垒中警戒可能出现的外敌。极少量的帝国公民在这里自发从事商业活动, 屯垦区的劳动力基本是用行政手段强行迁移过来的。总的来说, 古典帝国在这一区域的投入明显大于收入, 除非有优质的矿产, 统治这样的边疆更多是出于政治和军事意图。(上面这些内容观察一下汉魏晋和罗马的边疆自然就可以知道, 就不再详细说明) 可能会有人怀疑古典帝国的人口如果继续增加下去, 这样的模糊边疆会不会也能够发展成为坚实的内地, 作为进一步扩张的出发点。然而历史似乎否认了这种可能性, 人类社会的进步是波浪形的, 有的阶段突飞猛进, 有的阶段看起来陷入停滞。古典帝国没有机会用富余的劳动力去充实这些边疆, 在此之前它就会在封建化的进程中解体。实际上我们随后就会看到这种形式的边疆对于由蛮族主导的封建化具有相当大的意义。

总而言之, 古典帝国再强大它的疆域也会触碰到一个上界, 封建化最早就出现在这个地理范围内。如果人们观察欧洲的历史, 就很容易注意到整个中世纪早期封建政权的建立基本上没有越过罗马的最大疆域, 德意志地区的大规模开发是中世纪盛期才开始的。中国也是一样的, 就算后来官僚体制在我国复辟, 汉代所形成的文明疆域在东汉灭亡后十多个世纪内都长久不变, 只不过是汉代已经取得的边疆得到了充分开发。据说日本的《源氏物语》里面记载了一个十分传奇的故事, 说北条政子在少时做了一个梦, 在梦中她嫁给了一个“横卧在鬼界岛至外滨之间”的巨人, 用以证明源氏统治天下的合法性。从鬼界岛到外滨, 即从九州岛的最南端到本州岛的最北端就是当年终时日本的全部国土, 而横卧在这片国土上的巨人, 不就是将要治理这片土地的武士吗。大扩张在达到一个明确边界之后正式结束, 这个历史进程同样改变了整个社会的观念。想象一下飞鸟奈良时期的日本人会怎么看待世界, 对于他们来说, “征夷”无非是一个时机问题而没有技术难度, 只要朝廷有了余利余财, 把虾夷人继续向北击退不成问题。但是在《太平记》的年代社会意识就不可能如此了, 日本国家的疆域固定下来, 天下的土地你多一块, 我就要少一块。这样围绕土地占有形成的意识对于封建主义的形成起到了积极作用, 对于日本这样国情特殊的国家就更为重要, 此刻岛国的封闭性反倒成为了一件好事。

不过封建时期的特殊性就在于, 人们的观感跟社会发展的进退出现了不一致, 此处也是同样的道理。文明扩张到极限后人口的增加意味着土地越来越稀缺, 因为帝国境内易开发的新地已经基本开发完毕, 早期封建庄园兼并土地和蛮族的涌入加剧了这一点。糟糕的事情还未必只有这些, 人地关系紧张, 城市衰退和政治秩序瓦解还可能对公共卫生造成毁灭, 例如我们看到东汉末期和查士丁尼统治时期都出现了破坏极大的瘟疫蔓延。于是从大扩张时期形成一支延续到古典帝国盛期的自信, 开放, 包容, 积极, 乐观的情绪在一两个世纪间迅速消亡, 社会风气开始变得反理性, 怀疑主义盛行。人们对前途感到悲观,

思想和处事更加偏狭，这在当时无可厚非，因为当年的世界的确变得更不安全，人们没有理由对异己者怀有戒心。这里我尤其希望强调的是，尽管封建化刚刚发生的时候社会意识似乎是在倒退，但是很多在日后看来极有意义的变化已经发生了。例如人们在不得不摒弃了宏大的帝国叙事之后，开始更加关注个体的命运并进行个人创作，我国的《古诗十九首》就是这样的例子。人们不再关注曾经支配社会生活的大共同体，无论是朝廷、行省、军团还是国家教会，反正它们不是已经完蛋了就是自身难保。而是寻求个人的救赎和解脱，适应了这个趋势的宗教无疑取得了巨大的胜利，至今都在世界享有声望。知识分子开始思考世界变化的缘由以及人们应该如何度过艰难时日，明察和内省成为写作的主题，就像日本的《愚管抄》《徒然草》和《神皇正统记》。站在今天的角度来看，这些新的意识还很很不成熟，有的人的立场不在历史进步的一方，有些结论早就已经被否定了，但正是这世乱时危年代的思考成为天下平定的起点。

边界的不确定性会成为封建化阻碍还隐含着另一个很容易意识到的问题，那就是对于古典帝国来说这种游动的边界背后必然存在着“天险”之后庇护着的“化外之民”，而且人数不在不少，否则帝国有什么理由把边界推进到一个稳固的，易于防备的位置。该情况在南亚和东南亚广泛存在的热带季风气候控制的地区十分明显，这里森林密布，一年当中降水极不均衡。热带季风气候还不同于热带雨林气候，后者的降水在一年中比较均匀，但是前者在季风的影响下降雨极为集中在一年中不到三分之一的时间内，而漫长的旱季又分为热季和凉季。这一点跟温带差别确实很大，在北温带，太阳入射角最大的时候是夏至日，热量需要累积，因此一年中最热的时间在七、八月间。但是半个印度次大陆和几乎整个中南半岛都在北回归线以南，它意味着有很大一部分地区在夏至之前就已经被太阳直射过了，在北温带还处于春季的时候，这里已经变得极为酷热，到我们这个年代新闻上还经常报道印度在四、五月间出现大量人员中暑死亡。随着季风带来大量降水，极热得到了一定缓和，但是道路阻断，出行的风险剧增，即使是意志坚定，轻装前行的僧侣都不得不在雨季暂且安居，更不要说运送货物的商人和一支大军了。

整个古典时期的印度都不得不面临这样的情况，即使是政府能力也会随着季节而周期性地涨落，只有在凉季政治权力能投射到最大的范围，在雨季就萎缩了。这非常相似于学者们在描述东南亚历史的时候所提出的曼荼罗（Mandala）体制（南印度应当更为符合一些，毕竟开发较晚，人口较少，没有庞大而连片的肥沃平原。并且随着封建社会的发展这种现象一定是会被大幅消灭的，封建化意味着国家政治向面状转化，这一点在哪里都没有不同），缺少明确的国界，而是一种以强国为中心的附庸和朝贡关系，强调统治者之间的私人效忠，附庸也可以拥有自己的附庸体系，同时可以对于多个宗主称臣。虽然由于印度的历史进程发展较早，人口密度也就比较大，在印度的中世纪（从笈多王朝灭亡到莫卧儿帝国统治的巩固，时间上与欧洲非常接近，但是我认为其结束并不意味着已经发展到封建社会晚期，而是欧洲人到达比较早从而更早受到影响，乃至一步步沦为殖民地），随着人口增长和土地开发的进行，曼荼罗体制的影子最终从北印度和南印度都消失了。即使如此，在英国完全统治印度的19世纪后半叶，印度仍有1/10左右的人口生活在森林和丘陵地带，他们与其他印度居民最大的区别在于不分种姓，被称为“部落居民”，英国殖民政府在人口普查的时候也沿用了这一称谓。在早两个世纪的奥朗则布皇帝统治的年代，农民逃亡还是一个严重的问题，因为可耕地相对丰富。

这些事实都意味着，直到英国人在南亚次大陆的军事存在，对于本土统治者形成压倒性优势之前，从进入古典时代开始的2000年间，印度人虽然一直在压缩“内部边疆”，但是却并没有完成清除工作。这和温带地区形成了非常大的差异，人们根本无法想象在1840年的时候，清朝统治下的中国腹地有10%的人口，也就是4000万人游离在国家机器之外，视朝廷的法度为无物。在封建的欧洲和日本，这同样是不可想象的。森林、丘陵和山地印度文明的内部形成了庞大的“边疆地区”，这意味着即使到了中世纪领主的权力边界也并不容易确定。再早一些的古典帝国时代情况就更严重了，在欧亚大陆的几个古典帝国中，中国和罗马的边疆最为确定，而印度的孔雀王朝和笈多王朝最为模糊，基本上没有人能够准确指出这两个帝国的边境到底该怎么画，在南侧尤为如此。在“文明的印度”之外，始终有一个容纳部落成员，逃亡农民，平等主义者和不愿受政府管辖者的社会，这看起来很美好，但的确不利于封建制度的稳固。次大陆大大小小无数个社群在各自的领地发挥作用，国家政权只能试着驾驭它们却没办法把它们摧毁掉，这使得印度从整体上很难呈现出比较分明的阶级社会形态，游离在“领主-领民”这个体系外的人口无论是从总数上还是占比上实在多到过分了。一直到英国开始侵入前夕，社群的力量才出现显著衰退，不过据信现在社群也是印度的热门话题，往往作为政治动员的旗号出现，其影响力之巨大持久可见一斑。

伊朗也存在着相似的问题，虽然它的西部边疆因为处于近东的发达地区，但是面对东面的阿富汗和中亚方向边疆就十分模糊，北部的厄尔布尔士山脉历来属于抵抗者的天堂，连伊朗自己的中央政府都抵抗。考虑到伊朗地区（以萨珊帝国统治的领土为准）跟印度次大陆相比至少不会因为季节的周期变化而导致交通时通时断，政府权力时大时小，伊朗地区的“化外之民”的总人数和占比应该比印度小，可他们更具破坏性。印度的部落居民只想过自己的日子，他们既没有组织起来的需要也没有这样的欲望，他们只是对印度各地的政府表达一种抗拒，很少打算反过来进行入侵。伊朗山地中的部落完全不是这一回事，为了生存他们必须维持一定的武力，在时机合适的情况下并非没有可能在一个卡里斯玛式领袖的带领下征服混乱的伊朗，或者至少一部分，这在突厥人大迁徙之后更为明显。对伊朗来说，封建化进程开始较晚产生了一连串的连锁反应，在一波又一波入侵者的影响下，伊朗在中世纪真的进入了小说《三体》中的乱纪元。